

CASE STUDY · USER ACQUISITION

Cube Escape Collection

Q1 2026 UA performance analysis & Q2 action plan

36,839

daily data points

5

ad networks

15

countries · 3 tiers

10

prescriptive actions

Proposed £870/month reallocation with projected 35% ROAS uplift

01

Playable outperforms - gets less spend

Highest IPM (14.8 vs 10.3 benchmark) and lowest CPI, yet only 22% of budget. Static End Card gets 18% at half the IPM.

02

T2 Brazil is the efficiency sweet spot

£0.52 CPI, 11.8% D7 ROAS, beating France on ROAS at 85% lower cost per install. Under-funded today.

03

Creative fatigue is measurable

Top creative ran 42 days; benchmark refresh cycle is 7-14 days. IPM decayed 29% across the quarter.

Q2 projection if all 10 actions implemented

-16%

Blended CPI

£0.57 → £0.48

+18%

Total installs

91.8K → 108K

+35%

D7 ROAS

10.0% → 13.5%

+£3.3K

Revenue uplift

Q2 ad + IAP combined

A niche puzzle game • not a hyper-casual title

Cube Escape Collection

by Rusty Lake • released Oct 2020 • 5M+ downloads

Genre	Puzzle, escape room, point-and-click
Content	9 chapters, finite, LTV has a ceiling
Session	12-18 minutes, long for mobile
Rating	4.6★ Play • 4.7★ App Store
Monetisation	Rewarded ads (~72% T1), IAP hint packs
Lifecycle	Mature catalogue • paid UA is incremental

Embrace the niche features in UA strategy

- **Niche but loyal audience**
Puzzle D1 retention is 35-42% vs 25-30% for hyper-casual. Broad targeting burns spend on users who churn in seconds.
- **Finite content = LTV ceiling**
Nine chapters cap revenue per user. UA must hit payback before chapter completion, not after.
- **Distinctive art is the hook**
Surrealist visuals do the differentiation generic puzzle creatives never will. Lean into the aesthetic.
- **Cross-title upside is real**
Players who finish convert to Rusty Lake premium titles. Standard D7/D30 ROAS undercounts this.



Actual performance VS. Industry benchmarks

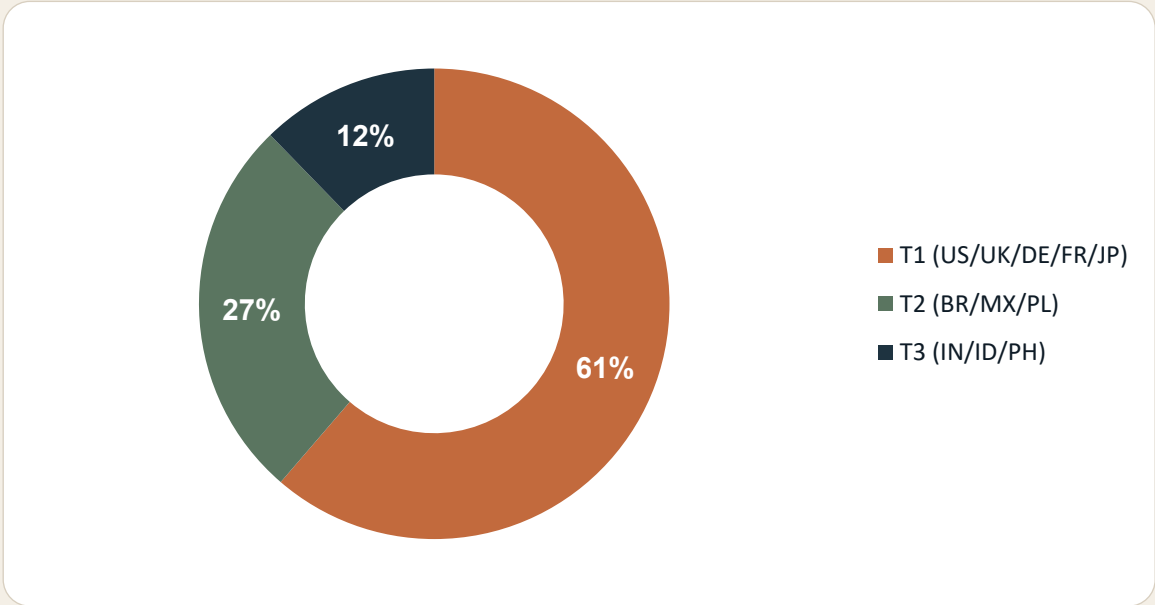
Sources: Liftoff 2025 · Admiral Media 2025 · Segwise 2025 · Unity 2024 · GameBiz 2026 · Amps33 2026

METRIC	BENCHMARK	OUR Q1 ACTUAL	READ
Puzzle CPI - T1 (US/UK/DE)	\$2.10 - \$4.50	£1.57	On benchmark - creative work can push lower
Puzzle CPI - T2 (BR/MX/PL)	\$0.35 - \$1.20	£0.51	Efficient - scale opportunity
D7 ROAS - casual puzzle	7.6% - 7.8% (Liftoff)	10.0% blended	Above benchmark - but T3 lags
IPM - puzzle genre	10.3 (Unity 2024)	14.8 (Playable)	Playable beats benchmark by 44%
Creative refresh cycle	7-14 days (GameBiz)	42 days top creative	3× over benchmark - fatigue burning IPM
IAP conversion rate	1.83% (Unity)	1.4%	Below benchmark - pricing test needed
TikTok CPI vs Meta	15-25% lower	18% lower	In range - shift budget at retention parity

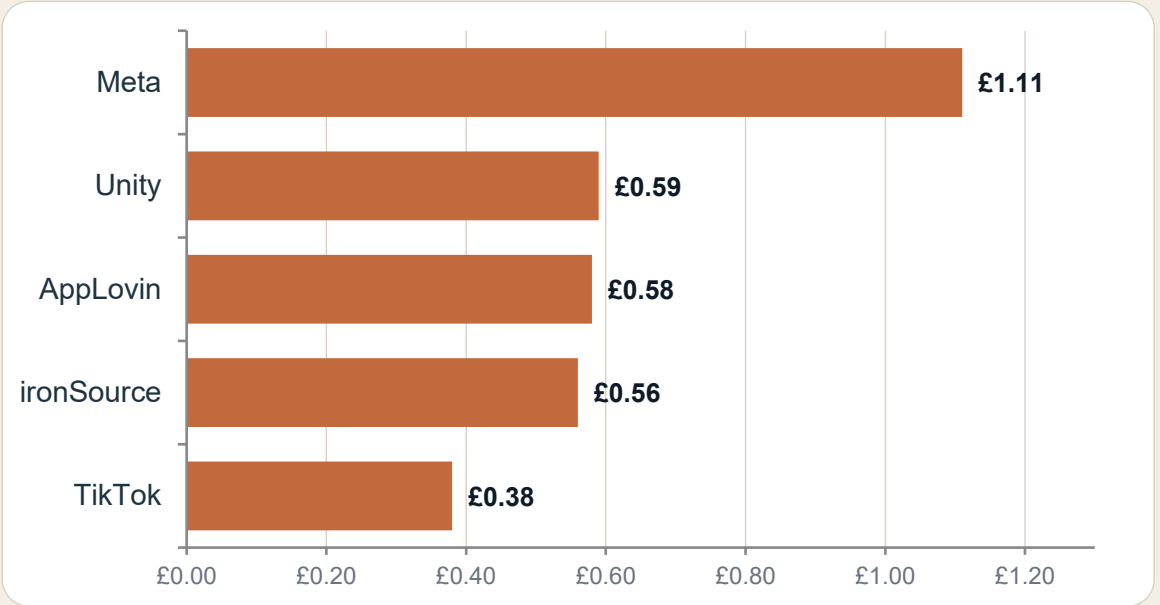
£52K spend • 91,770 installs • ahead of benchmark on aggregate

£52.4K Total spend	91,770 Installs	£0.57 Blended CPI vs £2.85 T1 bench	10.0% D7 ROAS vs 7.7% bench	£5,253 D7 revenue
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Spend share by region tier

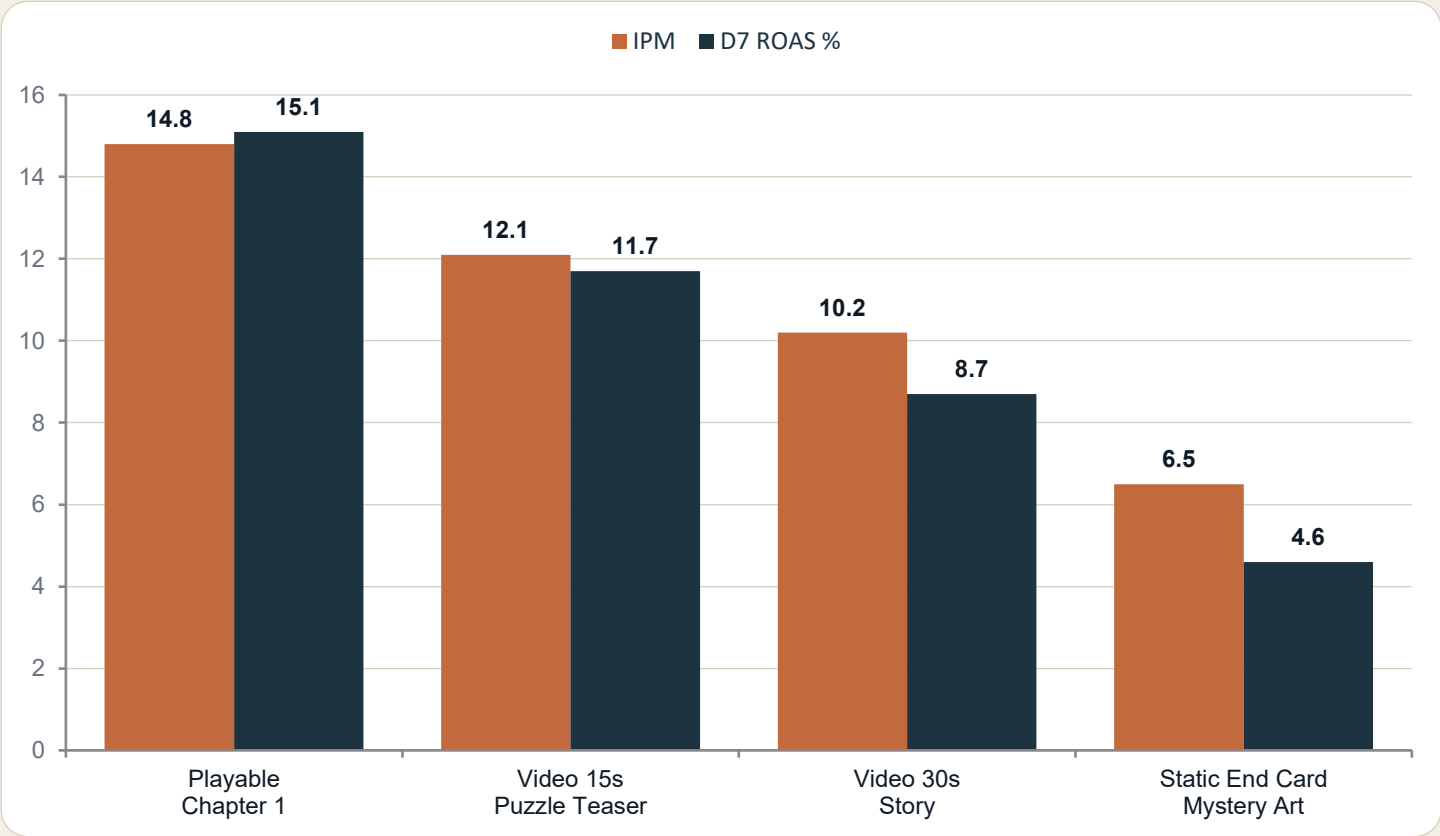


CPI by ad network • all installs



Playable wins on every metric - yet gets only 22% of budget

IPM and D7 ROAS by creative format



Puzzle IPM benchmark: 10.3 (Unity 2024)

THE MISMATCH

Static gets nearly the same budget as Playable

	% of spend	Cost / install
Playable	24.9%	£0.40
Static	25.2%	£1.11

RECOMMENDATION

Shift 80% of Static budget to Playable production.
Commission **3 new Playable variants** - Chapter 3 (The Mill), Chapter 5 (Case 23), Chapter 7 (Birthday) - for the rotation cycle.

T2 Brazil delivers T1-grade ROAS at 85% lower install cost

T1 · US/UK/DE/FR/JP

£1.57

CPI

7.2% D7 ROAS · 20,498 installs

On benchmark · creative work to push lower

T2 · BR/MX/PL

£0.51

CPI

11.8% D7 ROAS · 27,008 installs

Efficiency winner · under-funded today

T3 · IN/ID/PH

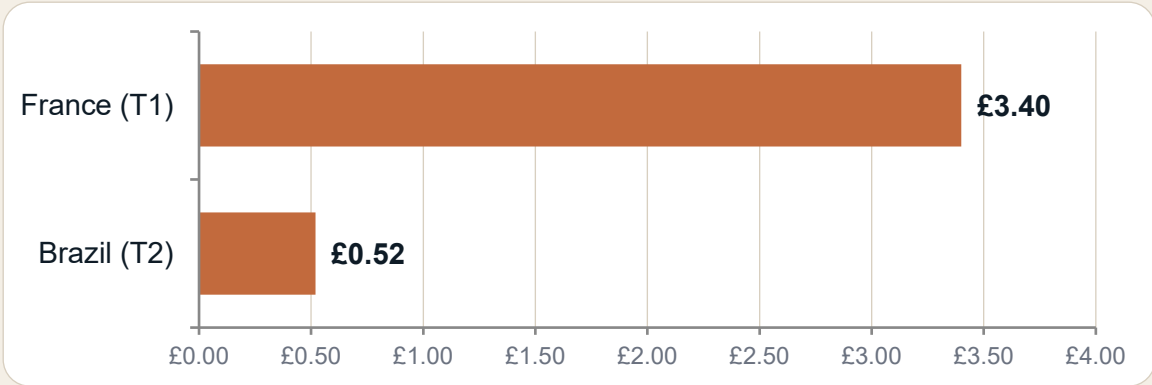
£0.15

CPI

20.4% D7 ROAS · 44,264 installs

Cheap installs · monetisation thin at scale

Brazil vs France: the same ROAS at a fraction of the cost



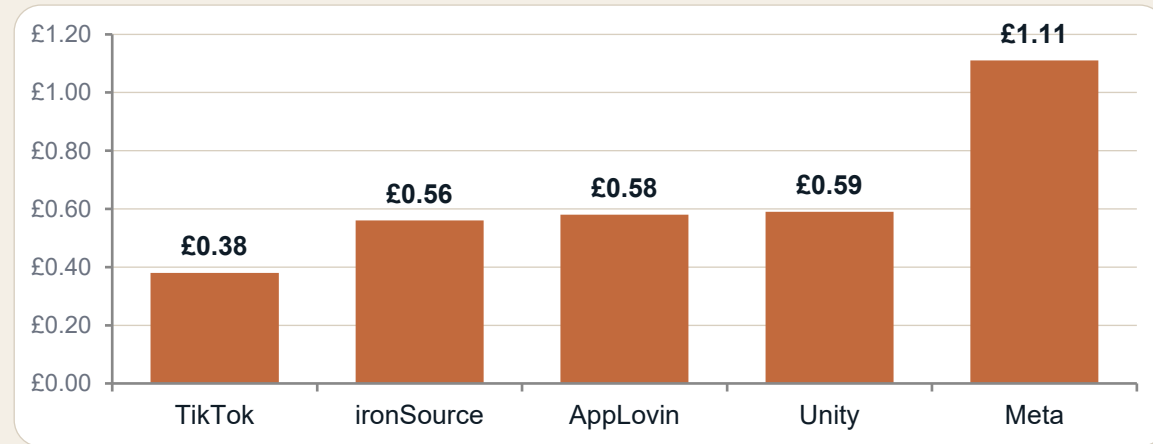
RECOMMENDATION

Increase Brazil daily budget by 40%

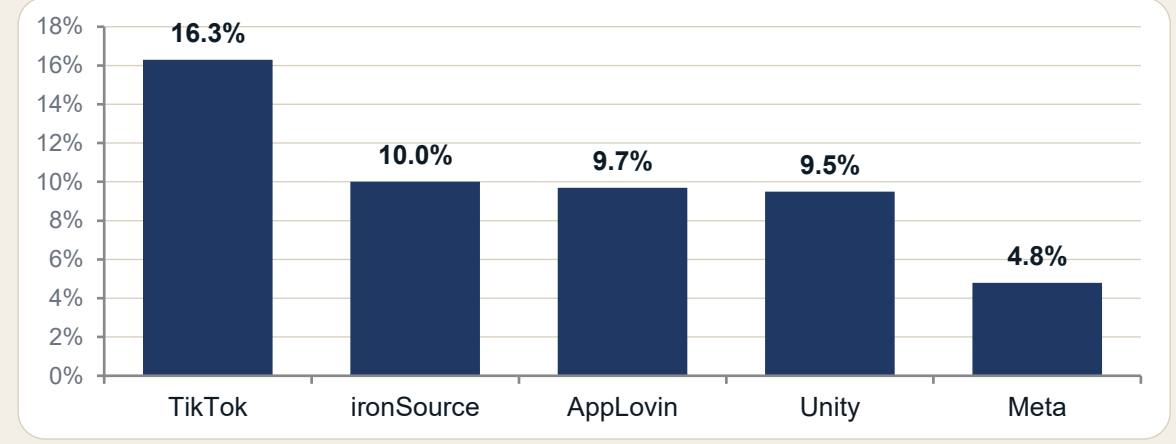
£72/day → £101/day · funded by cutting T3 India spend 50% (D7 ROAS 3.2% there is below the threshold where scaling is rational). Net +1,200 installs/month at no incremental cost.

TikTok is 18% cheaper than Meta - but the bidding stack needs to change

Cost per install by network



D7 ROAS by network



The CPI advantage is real and matches the industry signal

TikTok £0.38 vs Meta £1.11 -> TikTok is the cheaper trend for creative-heavy genres (GameBiz 2026's report accounting for 15-25%).

D7 retention is 2.1pp lower on TikTok

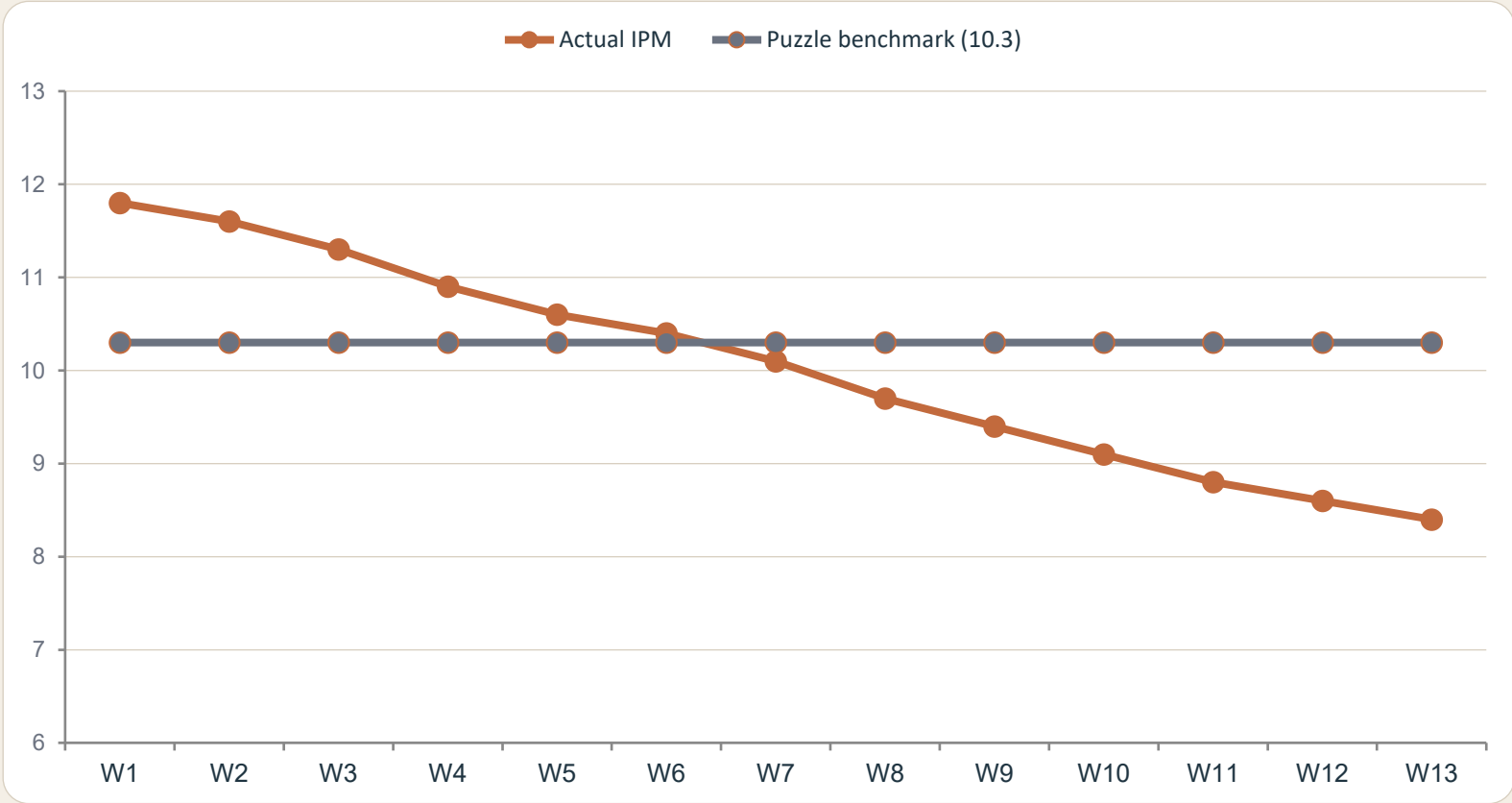
Suggests slightly lower-intent traffic - likely the cost of broader reach and shorter attention windows on the platform.

Action: scale TikTok 25% - but switch to ROAS-optimised bids

CPI bidding protects volume; ROAS bidding protects quality. Test TikTok-native UGC creatives ("solve along with me" format) before scaling further.

Top creative ran 42 days · IPM decayed 29% across the quarter

IPM trajectory - Video 30s (Story Atmosphere) · weekly average



THE PATTERN

-29%

IPM decline from W1 to W13

THE FIX

10-day rotation

Two new creatives per fortnight.
Swap at the 15% IPM-decline threshold (already crossed for the Video 30s).

Production budget: £800/month

One keyword change unlocks ~28,000 monthly searches

THE GAP

"escape room game"

28,000

monthly searches

Our current rank:

#62

Near-zero organic installs from one of the highest-volume terms in the genre.

Current App Store subtitle

"Rusty Lake's First Series"



Proposed subtitle

"Escape Room Puzzle Adventure | 9 Chapters Free"

Projected impact

30	+600	8 wks	£0
Target rank for keyword	Organic installs/month	Time to position	Cost

Proposed 10 actions plan

#	ACTION	WHERE	EXPECTED IMPACT	TIMING	COST
1	Shift 80% of Static End Card budget to Playable production	All tiers	-15% blended CPI, +22% IPM	Immediate	£0 reallocation
2	Commission 3 new Playable variants (Ch3, Ch5, Ch7)	T1, T2	3× creative lifespan	2 weeks	£1.5-2.5K
3	Increase T2 Brazil daily budget by 40%	T2	+1,200 installs/month at £0.52	Immediate	+£870/mo
4	Reduce T3 India spend 50%; reinvest in T2	T3 → T2	Net-zero spend, +ROAS quality	Immediate	-975/mo
5	Scale TikTok 25% · & switch to ROAS bidding	T1, T2	-18% CPI vs Meta at retention parity	1 week	+£1,200/mo
6	10-day creative rotation cycle	All	Prevent the 29% IPM decay	Ongoing	£800/mo
7	ASO: update subtitle + screenshots	All organic	+500-800 organic installs/mo	1 week	£0
8	Add 2nd rewarded ad placement per chapter	All	+15-20% ad revenue / session	2 weeks dev	Dev time
9	IAP: first-purchase discount (£0.99 starter)	T1	IAP rate 1.4% → 2.0% (benchmark 1.83%)	1 week	£0
10	iOS spend: T1 only · T2/T3 Android only	T2, T3	+8% ROAS via CPM/ARPDau ratio	Immediate	£0

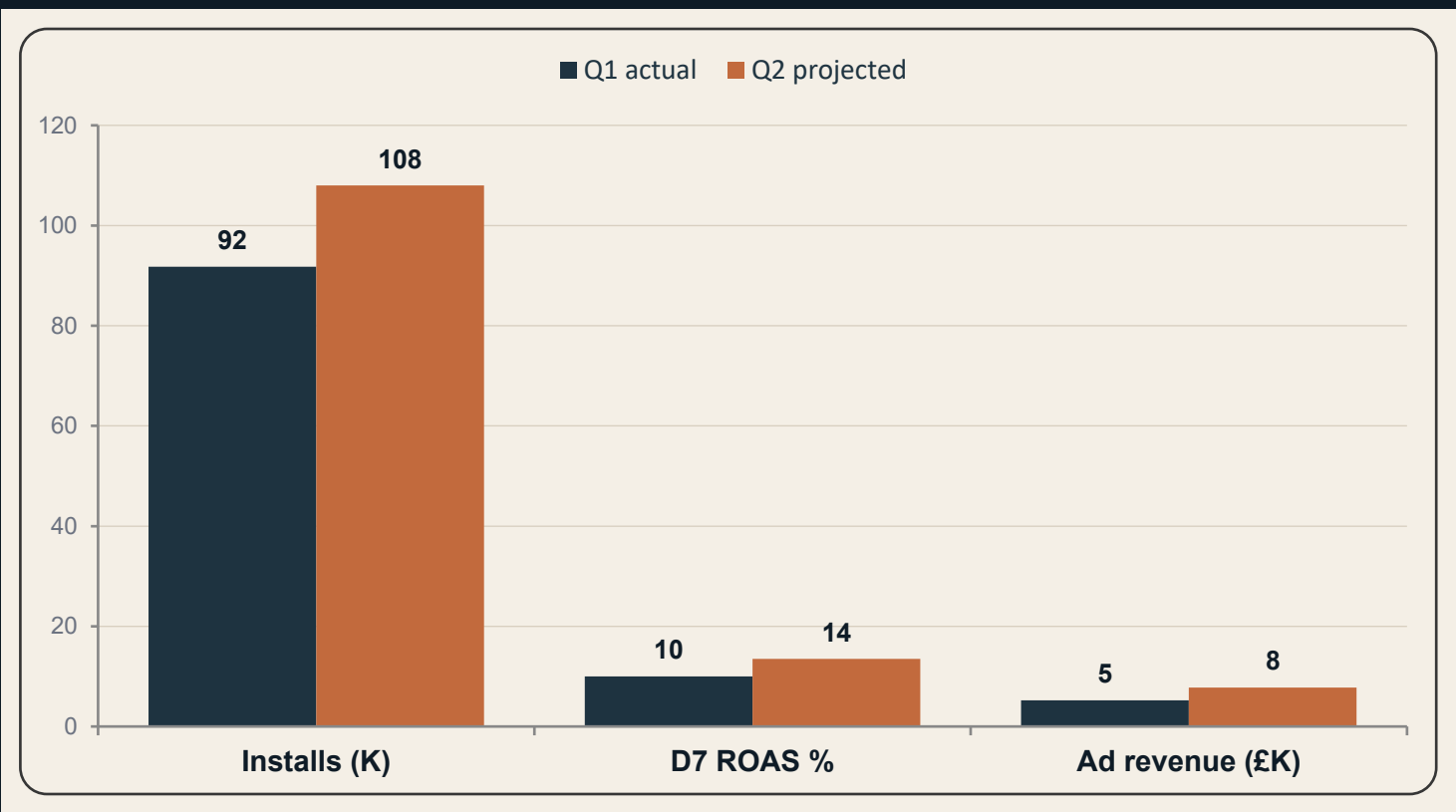
Net monthly spend change: +£895

Projected revenue uplift: +£3,300/quarter

Payback: under 1 month

If executed, Q2 closes the benchmark gap and reopens scaling room.

Q1 actual vs Q2 projected - core UA metrics



The bet is small (+£895/month), compared to the larger gains.

SCENARIO RANGE · D7 ROAS

PESSIMISTIC

11.2%

Half of actions land · creative refresh delayed

BASE

13.5%

All actions executed on plan

OPTIMISTIC

15.8%

ASO ranks faster · Brazil scales harder